

Payman Sharafian

Robotics & Mechatronics Engineer | Ph.D. Candidate | Machine Learning & Perception

Louisville, KY • **Work Authorization: 4 year EAD card (Green Card Pending) – No Sponsorship Required**

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Robotics and mechatronics engineer with 8 years of research and system-integration experience spanning physical human-robot interaction, teleoperation, safety-critical shared control, sensor fusion, and deep learning. Lead engineer on an NSF-funded omnidirectional mobile manipulator deployed in an active hospital unit, with end-to-end integration across real-time adaptive motion control, MPC-CBF safety filters, embedded firmware, perception pipelines, and IRB-approved human-subject trials. Proven track record of translating control theory and machine learning models into robust physical hardware performance across complex electromechanical systems

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Languages: Python, C, C++, MATLAB, C#, TypeScript/JavaScript, Bash

Robotics & Autonomy: ROS1 (Kinetic/Melodic/Noetic), ROS2 (Humble), Gazebo, RViz, Motion & Path Planning, MoveIt, ROS Navigation Stack (AMCL, costmaps), TF2, Kinova Kortex, Mecanum omnidirectional kinematics, URDF, NVIDIA Isaac Sim

Control & Optimization: PID/PD Loop Tuning (classical control), MPC, Control Barrier Functions (CBF-QP, MPC-CBF), OSQP, CasADi, Admittance/Impedance Control, Neuroadaptive Control, Lyapunov Stability Analysis, Genetic Algorithms (PyGAD), Real-Time Control, Kalman Filtering

Perception & ML: PyTorch, OpenCV, TensorFlow, Keras, Scikit-learn, ONNX, CUDA, Semantic Segmentation (zero-shot, FastSAM), Temporal Convolutional Networks, BiLSTM, CNN-GRU, MLP, PointNet++, FastSAM, Contact-GraspNet, Reinforcement Learning, multi-modal tactile + force/torque fusion

Embedded & Hardware: Linux, real-time embedded firmware (RTOS), series elastic actuators (SEA), EtherCAT Protocol, CAN, SPI, I2C, UART, Arduino, Teensy, STM32 Nucleo, Sabertooth motor drivers, Jetson, VersaLogic blackbird board, analog signal conditioning, SolidWorks (DFM/assembly), FDM and SLA 3D printing, PCB design/debug/soldering, FSR tactile arrays (FlexiForce A201), ATI Axia 80 F/T sensors, multi-channel data acquisition (DAQ), RealSense RGB-D, 3D LiDAR

Software & Infrastructure: distributed system architecture, CI/CD (GitHub Actions), Next.js (App Router), React, TypeScript, Tailwind CSS, WebSockets, rosbridge, Cloudflare, CBOR/JPEG stream compression, socket programming, Docker, Git

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Robotics Research Engineer (Ph.D. Research Assistant)

Sep. 2022 – Present

Louisville Automation & Robotics Research Institute (LARRI), University of Louisville

Louisville, KY

- Lead engineer on ARNA, the Adaptive Robotic Nursing Assistant funded by the NSF Future of Work program (#FW-HTF-RM): an omnidirectional mobile manipulator (a 7-DOF Kinova Gen3 arm on a Mecanum base) deployed on an active hospital unit. Responsible for its control, perception, embedded firmware, web infrastructure, and clinical trials.
- Built ARNA's complete remote-operation stack: network-aware safety filtering, secure browser transport, and one-click autonomous grasping. Validated it with **30 remote operators** across multiple U.S. cities, with every command crossing the public internet.
 - * Designed a five-layer shared-control stack for remote teleoperation that holds hard safety guarantees when *both* the operator and the connection are unreliable. Adaptive layers can only make the robot more cautious; barrier constraints are never relaxed. A 100 Hz arm MPC-CBF gave **zero boundary violations in 60 runs** at jerk cost **200–440× lower** than raw operator input; a 50 Hz OSQP base filter on LiDAR sectors gave zero margin violations; a watchdog scaled margins as the link degraded, with a 3.0 s dwell before recovery.
 - * Wrote a TypeScript/Next.js teleoperation interface an operator opens as a URL. Operators install nothing, and the robot exposes no inbound port; access runs over an outbound Cloudflare Tunnel with identity-based Access. Compiled it to a fully static bundle, so no Node runtime runs on the robot. Split the session across three isolated rosbridge instances so camera bursts cannot head-of-line-block a joystick or stop command, and cut per-frame data volume **~35–40×** with source-side JPEG encoding and CBOR subscriptions.
 - * Designed a semi-autonomous one-shot pick pipeline that reduces remote manipulation to a single click on the target object: FastSAM segments the clicked object on CPU, and Contact-GraspNet with a PointNet++ encoder proposes ranked SE(3) grasps. Highly optimized for a **4 GB laptop GPU (GTX 1060)** by cropping inference to the object bounding region (~10× input reduction) and warm-loading weights once at node start. Ranked grasp candidates by reachability instead of network confidence, which is what actually limited success.
- Led the sensorized handlebar and real-time adverse-event detector end to end: mechanical design, electronics, ML, and human trials. Built it around **eight FlexiForce A201 FSRs** and a custom Arduino signal-conditioning board publishing at **122 Hz**, fused with 6-axis F/T through a Singer-model Kalman filter. Benchmarked TCN vs. BiLSTM vs. CNN-GRU under subject-wise cross-validation, then deployed the TCN to ONNX onboard the robot, with no cloud, re-evaluating every **8.2 ms**. On **10 unseen participants: 85.0% detection at 2.05 s mean latency**.

- Designed PNNUI, a parallel-neural-network teleoperation interface that maps an arbitrary m -DOF input device onto an arbitrary n -DOF robot with no kinematic model of either: two networks in parallel, one searched offline by a genetic algorithm to minimize task time, one trained online by SGD against measured jerk. In a 20-subject IRB study, **linear jerk halved** and **angular jerk fell $\sim 3\times$** ($p < .001$), **with no increase in task-completion time**.
- Designed a model-free neuroadaptive admittance controller that learns ARNA's unmodelled dynamics online, with update laws derived from a Lyapunov analysis, running at 333 Hz against a 125 Hz admittance model. Against a tuned PD baseline with 10 users: tracking accuracy improved up to **32%** and motion jerk fell up to **52%**. Re-tuned with **63 nursing students**: velocity tracking error **0.0157 $\rightarrow$ 0.0105 m/s**, mean actuator torque **3.66 $\rightarrow$ 1.79 Nm**.
- Designed and led an acceptability trial on an active unit at University of Louisville Hospital with **10 patients and 5 nurses**. Paired objective task-time logging with Technology Acceptance Model instruments, analyzed with linear mixed-effects models in R: the joystick was significantly easier to use and more likely to be adopted than the tablet ($p \approx 0.02-0.03$) *despite statistically similar task times*.
- Repaired and upgraded ARNA's motor-controller PCBs, brought non-functional sonar and bump sensors back online and into ROS, repurposed the LiDAR for navigation, and rebuilt onboard wiring across the EtherCAT motor chain, Sabertooth motor drivers, Teensy microcontrollers, battery/inverter bank, and instrumentation board. Worked across the robot's serial and fieldbus layers (EtherCAT, CAN, SPI, I2C, and UART) to bring sensors and drives back under ROS control.
- Maintain and extend ARNA's embedded layer: a custom motor-controller PCB carrying **two Teensy microcontrollers** that must stay synchronised to drive the Sabertooth motor drivers coherently, speaking EtherCAT to the robot's main PC, plus an STM32 Nucleo handling the safety sensors. Maintained, debugged and repaired this firmware across several hardware revisions.
- Mentored **one M.S. student and six undergraduate researchers**, and authored the lab manuals and Standard Operating Procedures for ARNA that new researchers onboard from.

Mechatronics Engineer (M.Sc. Research Assistant)

Nov. 2017 – Sep. 2021

University of Tehran – Human-Robot Interaction Lab

Tehran, Iran

- Redesigned and built the mechanical powertrain and embedded electronics of a 1-DOF upper-limb rehabilitation robot driven by a series elastic actuator (equivalent torsional stiffness **8–30 Nm/rad**). Replaced belt drives with **08B-13** chains to stop slip under high load, added hardware safety interlocks (an ergonomic handle microswitch and an emergency stop), and integrated an Arduino Mega with **43 A** peak BTS7960 H-bridge drivers.
- Developed a torque-based PD impedance controller with active resistance that eliminated transition torque spikes and tracked trajectories to within **6.16–8.68% mean steady-state torque error** across **8–16 Nm** resisting loads. Built a C#/.NET serial bridge mapping joint motion into interactive web and Python games, and validated the system in a **15-subject** user study: **>90% motivation** and **86% perceived safety** ratings.
- Wrote a sound-source localization algorithm for an interactive social robot used in autism therapy. Audio filtering improved **70%** and gesture detection accuracy rose **40%**.

EDUCATION

Ph.D. Candidate, Electrical & Robotics Engineering, University of Louisville

Sep. 2022 – **Dec. 2026 (expected)**

M.S. in Mechatronics Engineering, University of Tehran

Nov. 2017 – Sep. 2021

B.Sc. in Electrical Power Engineering, Islamic Azad University

Sep. 2012 – Aug. 2017

SELECTED PUBLICATIONS

Full list: [Google Scholar](#)

- P. Sharafianardakani**, M. A. Hanafy, I. Kondaurova, A. Ashary, M. M. Rayguru, D. O. Popa. "Adaptive User Interface With Parallel Neural Networks for Robot Teleoperation." *IEEE Robotics and Automation Letters*, 10(2):963–970, 2025.
- P. Sharafianardakani**, S. Abubakar, S. K. Das, S. Surupa, M. A. Hanafy, M. Rayguru, D. O. Popa. "Evaluation of a Neuroadaptive Admittance Controller for Ambulation through Physical Human–Robot Interaction." *Intelligent Service Robotics*, 18(7):1355–1368, 2025.
- P. Sharafianardakani**, I. Kondaurova, A. Ashary, N. Zhang, M. C. Logsdon, M. Walker, D. O. Popa. "Hospital Trial Results for the Acceptability of an Adaptive Robot Nursing Assistant." *IEEE CASE*, pp. 2043–2049, 2025.
- I. Kondaurova, **P. Sharafian**, R. Mitra, M. M. Rayguru, *et al.*, D. O. Popa. "Acceptance of an Adaptive Robotic Nursing Assistant for Ambulation Tasks." *Robotics (MDPI)*, 14(9):121, 2025.
- M. C. Logsdon, I. Kondaurova, N. Zhang, *et al.* (incl. **P. Sharafianardakani**), D. O. Popa. "Perceived Usefulness of Robotic Technology for Patient Fall Prevention." *Workplace Health & Safety*, 72(12):542–549, 2024.
- P. Sharafianardakani et al.** "Tactile Handlebar and Deep Learning for Safe Interaction with a Robot Nursing Assistant." *IEEE Transactions on Medical Robotics and Bionics* – **under review**.

LEADERSHIP & AWARDS

Journal Reviewer, IEEE Robotics and Automation Letters (RA-L), 2024–2025
Mentor, 7 undergraduate and 2 graduate students, 2023–Present

• **Conference Reviewer**, ACM/SIGAPP SAC, 2024 • **STEM**

Dissertation Completion Award (full tuition + stipend), University of Louisville, 2026
Graduate Student Travel Award, 2025

• **IEEE RAS Travel Support Award** (ICRA 2025) •